AAOE American Association of Orthopaedic Executives
American Alliance of Orthopaedic Executives

Stephanie Carlton, Deputy Administrator
Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services
Department of Health and Human Services
Attention: CMS-0042-NC
P.O. Box 8013
Baltimore, MD 21244-8013

RE: Request for Information (RFI): Health Technology Ecosystem

Dear Deputy Administrator Carlton,

On behalf of the American Association of Orthopaedic Executives (AAOE), representing over 1,500 orthopaedic practice executives and leaders across the United States, we appreciate the opportunity to provide input in response to the RFI on the Health Technology Ecosystem. AAOE supports CMS and the Assistant Secretary for Technology Policy/Office of the National Coordinator for Health Information Technology (ASTP/ONC) in their commitment to enhancing digital health capabilities and data interoperability, thereby empowering patients and providers and advancing value-based care.

Provider Workflows and Digital Health Tools

Orthopaedic practices continue to face significant challenges in adopting digital health tools that can meaningfully improve patient care and reduce administrative burdens. According to a 2024 MGMA Stat poll**,** nearly 72% of medical group leaders said that current digital health tools often fail to integrate seamlessly into existing workflows. Orthopaedic practices are no exception; fragmented data systems and lack of interoperability remain significant hurdles.

We urge CMS to prioritize the following actions to support providers better:

- Integration with Practice Management Systems: Orthopaedic practices rely heavily on specialized practice management systems that are often not fully interoperable with broader electronic health record (EHR) platforms. CMS could incentivize technology vendors to develop standardized APIs that seamlessly integrate with these systems, reducing duplicate data entry and improving care coordination.
- Streamlined Quality Data Reporting: In 2024, the AMA's Digital Health Study reported that practices spend over 20 hours per week on manual data entry and reporting tasks, thereby limiting the time available for patient care. CMS can alleviate this burden by leveraging bulk FHIR data exports from EHRs to enable centralized calculation of quality metrics, as outlined in the RFI's PR-8 question.

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Data Exchange and Interoperability

The January 2025 report by the Office of the National Coordinator for Health IT found that over 55% of providers still encounter barriers to sharing patient data across systems. While the CMS Interoperability and Patient Access final rule has driven important progress, AAOE members report that orthopaedic practices still struggle with incomplete or delayed access to patient data, which is vital for preoperative assessments and post-acute care management.

To address this, we recommend:

- Enhancing API Functionality**:** Expand Blue Button 2.0 to include operative reports, imaging data, and patient-reported outcomes—crucial for orthopaedic care. Currently, the exclusion of such data limits the value of digital health tools in orthopaedics.
- Support for Small and Rural Practices: Many orthopaedic practices operate in rural or resource-constrained settings. CMS should ensure that new interoperability standards consider the technical limitations and staffing capacity of these practices, offering targeted support and funding for implementation.

Digital Identity, Privacy and Value-Based Care Alignment

AAOE members recognize the growing promise of digital identity credentials (e.g., CLEAR, Login.gov, ID.me) in enhancing patient data access and streamlining administrative processes. However, any implementation must ensure that privacy and trust remain paramount, with strong adherence to HIPAA and other privacy standards. Additionally, CMS should collaborate with professional associations like AAOE to develop resources and training that support both provider and patient adoption of these tools.

At the same time, orthopaedic practices continue to engage in value-based care models, including bundled payments and advanced alternative payment models (APMs). As CMS integrates digital identity strategies into federal programs, it should ensure alignment with value-based care principles, allowing for seamless, secure, and efficient patient and provider engagement.

Promoting Competition and Innovation

We support CMS's vision of fostering a vibrant market of digital health solutions that improve patient care and choice. We recommend:

- Public-Private Partnerships**:** CMS should partner with specialty associations, such as AAOE, to identify orthopaedic-specific data needs and support pilot projects that test innovative digital health tools.

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AAOE appreciates CMS and ASTP/ONC's leadership in driving a more patient-centric, digital-first healthcare system. Orthopaedic practices are committed to providing high-quality, evidence-based care, and robust digital health tools and interoperable data infrastructure are essential to achieving this goal.

We look forward to continued engagement and offer our expertise to inform future policies and implementation efforts. Thank you for your consideration of these comments.

Sincerely,

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